

AGGRESSIVE STANCE Indian and Chinese troops engaged in close combat in Galwan, June 2020



Jun. 29, 2020



The Tough Road Ahead
INDIA TODAY, *Feb. 10, 2020*

"When four JeM terrorists struck the Pathankot air base on January 1, 2016, they exposed abysmal coordination among the services at the apex level. Exactly four years later, India's first chief of defence staff (CDS), Gen. Bipin Rawat, told the media that his job would be "to achieve more through integration". "The synergised efforts should not be the sum total of the three. It should be more," he said."

Pakistan's riposte and the brief capture of IAF pilot Abhinandan Varthaman underscored the risks.

With China, the challenge has simmered. The 2017 Doklam standoff showed how quickly infrastructure and patrol disputes could spiral. The deadly clash in Ladakh's Galwan Valley in June 2020, the first combat fatalities on the India–China border in decades, shattered long-held assumptions about peace along the Line of Actual Control. What followed was a protracted military mobilisation: forward deployments, armour hauled to altitude, and a winter posture that has yet to fully unwind.

These twin pressures accelerated institutional reform. The creation of the post of Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) in 2019, and the push towards theatre commands under General Bipin Rawat, aimed to break service silos and enable joint warfighting. Rawat's death in a helicopter crash in 2021, and lingering inter-service differences, slowed momentum, but the logic of integration remains compelling. At the same time, the government has pushed 'Make in India' in defence—expanding domestic procurement, encouraging private manufacturers and curbing imports. The rollout of the contentious Agnipath recruitment scheme in 2022 was intended to create a younger, leaner force, but has drawn criticism for its implications for unit cohesion and veterans' welfare.

Intent is clear. Endurance will decide outcomes. ■



Baptism by Fire
INDIA TODAY, *Jul. 4, 2022*

"When the Modi government introduced Agnipath, a "transformative recruitment scheme" aimed at improving the battle-readiness of the Indian armed forces by infusing young blood, officials did not anticipate the scale of resistance it would provoke.... The top military leadership sent an unambiguous message: there would be no rollback, eligible applicants found to have participated in the violence would be disqualified."